

ONE MAN MISSION

It has been 15 years since Panchayati Raj was ushered in by the 73rd Amendment of the Constitution. But nearly four years after taking charge, Mani Shankar Aiyar is still fighting a lonely battle against a mindset to make it a reality.

■ **By Shankkar Aiyar**

He sits in Vigyan Bhavan in the Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region. The secretary sits in Krishi Bhavan; the additional secretary in Sardar Patel Bhavan and the joint secretary in Samrat Hotel. You could say the Panchayati Raj is homeless without an address in India's political capital. Last week, Panchayati Raj Minister Mani Shankar Aiyar went on a tour of Krishi Bhavan to find himself some space. As he trudged amidst the mess of carpenters and masons, it must have occurred to Aiyar that his quest for physical space in many ways was symbolic, an apt metaphor for his quest to find political space for Panchayati Raj.

Consider this to get a sense of the magnitude of the challenge. Panchayati Raj was formally ushered in by the 73rd constitutional amendment in 1993 but till 2004, it didn't even have a division, leave alone a ministry. Today there are 2,33,606 gram panchayats, 6,094 intermediate or taluka panchayats and 543 zilla panchayats. These three tiers have elected 26 lakh representatives. Indeed, the 10 lakh women representatives outnumber all the elected women representatives world over. Yes, there is the existence of surrogate representation, the phenomenon of "sarpanch pati". But the counter is that they are

elected and the surrogate phenomenon is prevalent in other electoral forum too. Be that as it may numerical strength has not helped the children of a lesser democracy. Although the 73rd constitutional amendment specifies devolvement of 29 subjects to panchayats, nearly a dozen of the 30 states are yet to comply. True devolution of power has thus eluded panchayats.

Resistance is across party lines—DMK had voted against the 73rd amendment, AIADMK had abstained and NCP is not a willing participant. It is not limited to the states either. Even after the ministry was announced in 2004, it took over 150 days for Aiyar to decide on what the ministry could do and could not. Obviously, allies within the UPA, particularly those like the Rural Development Ministry headed by Raghuvansh Prasad Singh, were not keen to yield ground on what was their share of coalition power. Aiyar carved out a ministry with a staff of 60 and an equal number of consultants are paid for by the UNDP. In the first 150 days, he had conducted seven roundtables, drawn out 150 action points and a road map that was sent to all chief ministers. Till date, he has visited 22 states, attended 200 gram sabhas, 100 taluka samitis and 50 zilla sabhas. In a burst of Aiyarism, he quips, "I normally sit with the samiti members on the grass and have a pretty good idea of the grassroots issues."